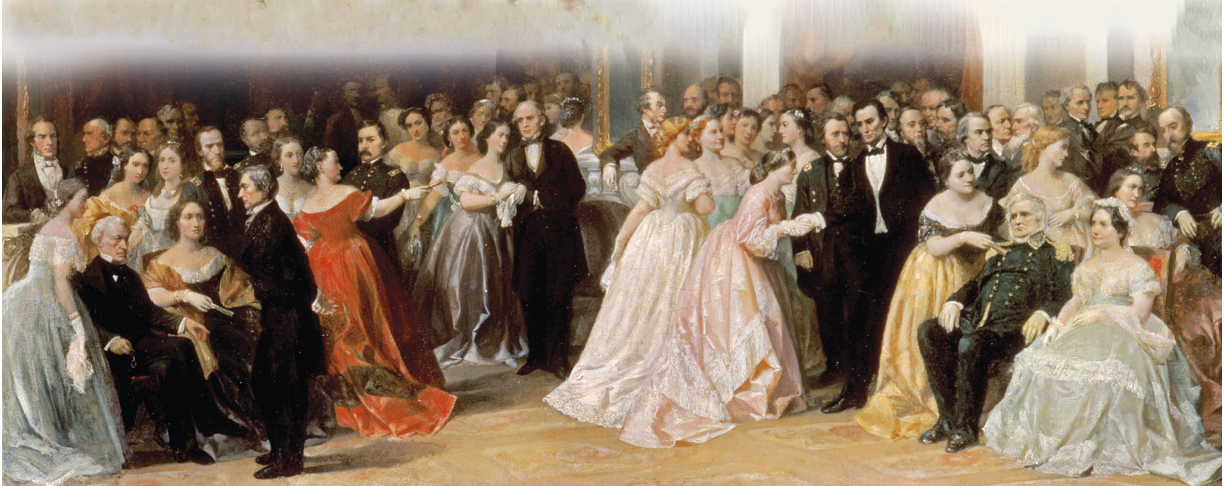




Grant at the White House

Peter Rothermel's 1867 painting *The Republican Court in the Days of Lincoln* depicts the reception at which Lincoln welcomed Grant to Washington as the army's new general-in-chief. It still hangs in the White House.

A two-horse race

Frémont saw the Democratic platform as tantamount to “Union with Slavery,” and withdrew his candidacy. Winning the war was, to him, more important than winning the presidency. That left Lincoln and McClellan to battle it out. Across the North, campaign ribbons and bunting vied with fall leaves for color. People sported their candidates’ badges; broadsides (newspaper bulletins) and cartoons endorsed one nominee and decried the other. In camps and trenches, troops of both North and South huddled around grimy newspapers. Depending on the camp or trench, the news of General William T. Sherman’s taking of Atlanta or General Philip Sheridan’s clearing of the Shenandoah Valley was met with either cheers or curses. As the tide of Union victories planned by Grant finally rolled in, it began crushing the hopes of the Confederacy. November 8 was Election Day. After the ballots were counted, Lincoln had won by over 400,000 votes, securing an overwhelming majority in the Electoral College. His soldiers had given him over 70 percent of their support. For the president and his commanding general, the scent of victory was in the fall air.